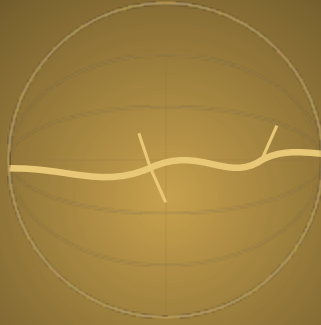




THE GOLD DECISION FRAMEWORK — BOOK 1

The Gold Investor

Building Your Own Gold Thesis

Filip Allaert

THE GOLD DECISION FRAMEWORK

The Gold Investor Building Your Own Gold Thesis

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

With a background in WTI crude oil and FX trading, the author approaches gold from a market-structure, macroeconomic and risk-management perspective.

This framework is not designed to tell readers what to buy or when to buy it. It is designed to help them ask better questions, conduct their own research, and take responsibility for their decisions.

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COLOPHON

The Gold Investor — Book 1

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DISCLAIMER

This book is intended for educational purposes and does not constitute personal investment advice. Decisions about purchasing precious metals remain the reader's own responsibility.

Historical returns are no guarantee of future performance. Consult an independent financial adviser where appropriate.

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PRELUDE

The Titanic Shift

*What central banks, governments, and a closed strait
are telling you about money*



DISPATCH — SEPTEMBER 2026

I — OPENING & CENTRAL BANKS

There's a pattern hiding across a dozen headlines this year that most people are reading as separate stories.

A pension fund quietly cutting its US bond holdings. A central bank buying gold at the fastest pace in a decade. A war in the Persian Gulf. Wheat jumping double digits in a week. A US Treasury Secretary intervening in currency markets using euros instead of dollars, then buying back his own country's bonds days later.

Read individually, none of it seems urgent. Read together, it's the same story told six different ways: the institutions that manage money at the largest scale on Earth no longer fully trust the old arrangement — and they're quietly repositioning around that.

You don't need a finance degree to understand what's happening. You need about ten minutes and the willingness to connect dots most financial media covers separately.

Central banks stopped trusting the old "safe" asset

For thirty years, the default reserve asset for a central bank was the US Treasury bond. Boring. Liquid. Guaranteed.

That default is breaking. According to the European Central Bank's own 2025 review, gold overtook the euro to become the second-largest reserve asset held by central banks globally — trailing only the dollar. Some analyses go further, showing that for the first time since 1996, foreign central banks collectively hold more gold than US Treasuries. Central banks bought over 1,000 tonnes of gold a year in each of the last several years, more than double the pace of the previous decade.

II — PENSION FUNDS & GOVERNMENT INTERVENTIONS

This isn't one country making a bet. It's a broad, sustained pattern across dozens of central banks — the kind of shift that happens slowly, then all at once.

Europe's pension funds are showing the same instinct with their own money. ABP, the Netherlands' largest pension fund, cut its US Treasury holdings by roughly €10 billion in just six months last year — a real, disclosed, decade-scale retreat from US government debt. We don't know with certainty where that money went. What we do know is that one of Europe's most conservative institutional investors decided holding fewer US Treasuries was the safer move.

Governments are now actively managing the cracks

Here's the part most people miss, because it happened in the span of a few weeks in August: the US government itself started intervening directly in its own bond and currency markets — and the way it did it is unusual enough to be a signal on its own.

Early in the month, the US joined Japan in defending the yen — the first American yen intervention in fifteen years. But instead of selling dollars to buy yen, the US Treasury sold euros. That's not a small technical detail. Selling dollars would have meant printing more dollar liquidity or leaning on Treasury sales. Selling euros avoided both — and, just as importantly, it kept Japan (the largest single foreign holder of US government debt) from having to dump its own Treasury holdings to defend its currency.

Two weeks later, with the 30-year Treasury yield hitting its highest level in nearly two decades as US federal debt crossed \$40 trillion, the Treasury Department doubled its own bond buyback program — effectively managing its own borrowing costs directly, because the market wasn't doing it for them. The move worked for about a day before yields rose right back.

Put those two events side by side and you get a government actively engineering support for its own currency and its own debt market, in real time, using unconventional tools. That's a different posture than "the dollar is a safe haven so people are buying it" — it's closer to "the people responsible for the dollar and the debt are worried enough to intervene directly."

III — WAR, OIL & THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ

War turned one chokepoint into a live pressure gauge

Since February 2026, a war between Iran, Israel, and (indirectly) the US has kept the Strait of Hormuz — the passage for roughly a fifth of the world's oil — in a state of near-constant disruption. Oil has swung wildly: from around \$61 a barrel before the war to a March peak above \$114, crashing nearly 9% in a single session when the US signaled it might seize the strait directly, and easing again this week as Iran and Oman negotiate a temporary shipping corridor. A tanker was still hit by an unidentified projectile near the strait just days ago.

What's genuinely interesting isn't just that oil moved — it's how gold responded to it, and that response changed shape three times over the course of the year:

- For most of the war, rising oil pushed inflation fears up, which pushed interest-rate expectations up and strengthened the dollar — both of which are headwinds for gold. Oil up, gold down or flat.
- Briefly this spring, that flipped: markets started reading the closed strait as a broader growth shock rather than an inflation shock, and gold rallied alongside oil.
- Now, in the past month, it's flipped again in the other direction: falling oil (on ceasefire hopes) is lowering inflation fears and reviving rate-cut expectations — so gold is rising as oil falls.

The lesson isn't "gold always goes up in a crisis." It's that the channel — inflation, growth, or interest-rate expectations — determines the relationship, and that channel can change mid-conflict. Anyone trading or holding commodities through this period who assumed a fixed relationship between war and gold has likely been wrong at least twice this year.

IV — FOOD MARKETS & THE COMMON THREAD

And now food is repricing too

While all of this has played out in metals and energy, agricultural markets have quietly caught fire. Wheat jumped by its daily trading limit this week on fears that Black Sea grain exports — already disrupted by drone strikes on Russian port infrastructure — would tighten further. Corn hit a fresh multi-year high after a private crop tour cut the expected US harvest well below the government's own forecast. Soybeans followed on strong Chinese buying.

Three separate risk premiums — weather-driven crop losses, war-driven export disruption, and demand strength — are stacking on top of each other in the same commodity complex at the same time. That's not a coincidence tied to precious metals or oil specifically. It's the same underlying condition showing up in a third, completely different market: when confidence in the old monetary and geopolitical order wobbles, it doesn't stay contained to one asset class.

The common thread

Strip away the individual headlines and you're left with one throughline: governments and institutions are less confident than they were a year ago that the existing arrangement — dollar dominance, Treasury bonds as the default safe asset, stable trade and shipping routes — will hold without active management. Central banks are hedging with gold. Pension funds are quietly reducing exposure. Governments are intervening directly in currency and bond markets to hold things together. War is repeatedly testing the physical infrastructure — a strait, a port, a supply route — that the whole system depends on. And commodities, from gold to oil to wheat, are the place where all of that uncertainty gets priced in real time.

V — WHERE THE READER SHOULD START

None of this means collapse is coming, and it isn't a call to panic. Institutions moving carefully over months, not selling everything overnight, is itself the signal — this is repositioning, not fleeing. But it is a genuinely different environment than the one most people built their financial assumptions around over the last few decades.

Where to actually start

You don't need to track central bank flows, Treasury buyback schedules, and Black Sea shipping routes to benefit from understanding this shift. You need to understand the piece that's most directly actionable for an individual: precious metals — what actually drives their price, how the market for buying them physically works, and how to do it without overpaying.

That's the starting point, not the whole picture. Commodities beyond gold — energy, agriculture, industrial metals — are shaped by the same forces described above, and each has its own mechanics worth understanding on their own terms. Consider this letter the map. The guide that follows is where you learn to read the terrain up close.

History offers a blunt reminder of how unpredictable capital becomes once confidence in the prevailing monetary order starts to crack. Writing about the 1931 sovereign debt crisis, Herbert Hoover recalled capital that "behaved like a loose cannon" moving between countries as fear displaced calculation. Ninety years on, the mechanics are faster — but the underlying behavior, capital searching for safety when trust in the system itself is in question, is the same one this prelude has been describing.

📖 READING THIS PRELUDE THE WAY CHAPTER 8 TEACHES

Observation: central banks have been buying gold at a record pace since 2022; several — the Netherlands, France, Norway's NBIM — have recently moved gold or trimmed Treasury exposure; a handful of governments have intervened directly in currency and bond markets this year.

Interpretation offered in this prelude: institutions are growing less confident that the existing dollar-centered order will hold without active management, and are repositioning accordingly.

What would weaken this interpretation: a sustained multi-quarter reversal in central bank gold buying; major reserve managers resuming net Treasury accumulation; the DNB, French, and NBIM moves turning out to be one-off portfolio adjustments rather than the start of a pattern when the next World Gold Council report lands.

This is the same structure Chapter 8 will ask you to apply to your own thesis. It's applied here first so you can hold this prelude's claims to the same standard the rest of the book asks of you.

SOURCES & FURTHER READING — PRELUDE

De Nederlandsche Bank — official statements on gold relocation, September 2026

European Central Bank — "The International Role of the Euro," 2025 review

World Gold Council — central bank gold demand data

Reuters and other financial press coverage of the Bessent yen/euro intervention and US Treasury buyback program, 2026

News coverage of Norway's NBIM Treasury-weighting proposal, 2026

Herbert Hoover, *The Memoirs of Herbert Hoover: The Great Depression, 1929-1941* (Macmillan, 1952), Volume II

I

Real Interest Rates & the Dollar

*When money becomes cheaper than the risk it
carries, capital shifts toward what cannot be
printed.*



Why this is the first chapter

If there's one relationship you need to understand before opening a single commodities position, it's this one: the relationship between real interest rates, the dollar, and the price of gold and silver. Almost every other factor in this guide — geopolitics, supply/demand, mining supply — operates within the framework this relationship sets. Once you understand this, you'll immediately see why precious metals sometimes rise despite bad news, and fall despite good news.

One framing note before we go further: gold is the anchor asset throughout this book. Silver, platinum, and copper appear repeatedly in the chapters ahead — not as a broader commodities course, but because comparing them to gold is often the clearest way to see what actually makes gold different.

The fundamental concept

Real interest rates are simple: the nominal rate (what your bank or government pays you) minus inflation.

What is the real interest rate?

The real interest rate is simple: the nominal rate (what your bank or the government pays you) minus inflation. If a 10-year government bond yields 4% and inflation is 3%, your real rate is 1%.

This number matters more than the nominal rate itself, because it determines whether holding cash grows or shrinks your purchasing power.

Why gold reacts to this

Gold pays no interest or dividend. Holding it instead of an interest-bearing asset therefore "costs" you something — this is called the opportunity cost.

- When real rates rise, that opportunity cost increases: bonds and savings now genuinely yield something above inflation, making gold relatively less attractive. All else equal, this tends to pressure gold downward.
- When real rates fall or turn negative, holding gold costs you little or nothing — in fact, holding cash loses purchasing power. Gold becomes relatively more

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